

Breaking from the Party Line: Understanding Atypicality Effects in Citizens' Issue Arguments

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Citizens' political attitudes are more idiosyncratic than elites'. As a result, when citizens engage in issue-specific persuasion, they are more likely to advance arguments that depart from what is typical for their party. Such atypical arguments may differ in the style they adopt or the considerations they emphasize. We report results from a study identifying the persuasive consequences of such atypical arguments and distinguishing content-grounded from expectancy-grounded pathways. First, a content analysis shows that typical and atypical arguments differ in both style and the substantive considerations they raise. Then, in an experiment, we find that atypical arguments from out-partisans are perceived as more compelling, while atypical arguments from in-partisans are perceived as less compelling. Both effects emerge primarily when the author's partisanship is hidden, pointing to a content-grounded pathway. Citizens with atypical views shape political discussion through how they engage with issues—not merely by violating partisan expectations.

In June of 2025, the Southern Baptist Convention adopted a resolution calling for a reversal of the *Obergefell v. Hodges* Supreme Court decision, which legalized same-sex marriage throughout the United States (Graham 2025).¹ Arthur—an acquaintance of an author—took to social media to voice an opinion.² He remarked, “I believe that love is love, and that all individuals, regardless of sexual orientation, should have the freedom to live their lives authentically and without interference. . . . I firmly support equal rights for everyone, including the right to marry the person they love. Personal

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¹Claude Opus versions 4.6 and 4.7 were used to support data coding and figure creation and to revise prose for clarity and concision. The authors maintained oversight by 1) drafting the first version of all prose, 2) carefully reviewing every suggested edit, and 3) cross-checking each line of code for accuracy. The authors take full responsibility for the accuracy and integrity of all reported analyses and written content.

²This individual's name has been changed to protect his identity.

liberty and equality under the law are values that I hold deeply.”

Arthur’s comment would have been unremarkable—one of the countless examples of casual citizen political commentary—were it not for its source. Anyone even lightly acquainted with Arthur’s social media profile would quickly glean that he is a gun-toting Marine Corps veteran, a conservative, and a vocal supporter of Donald Trump. Shortly before his same-sex marriage post, Arthur approvingly posted a video of Robert F. Kennedy, Jr., excoriating Democrats during a congressional hearing. In the weeks after the marriage post, he wrote, “F___ the left. . . Look at what they actually celebrate: hate, violence, rage, and destruction. If you want to be on the right side of history, it’s time to walk away.” To anyone who knows him, Arthur’s marriage comment was atypical.

While atypical policy opinions are not the norm, neither are they rare. Scholars have long observed weak ideological constraint within the mass public (Converse 1964). A natural implication of this reality is that many citizens develop one-off (“morselized” in Lane’s 1962 phrasing) opinions about specific topics. For a simple illustration, the 2024 American National Election Studies Time Series study included a battery of 17 policy questions with a clear liberal or conservative valence. Thirty-four percent of self-described Democrats who answered these questions endorsed the most *conservative* position on multiple policies; 57% of self-described Republicans endorsed the most *liberal* position on multiple policies. (See Supporting Information, Section 4.1, for details on this analysis.) Consistent with these patterns, other work finds large swaths of American voters endorse idiosyncratic mixtures of liberal and conservative opinions (Broockman 2016; Broockman and Lauderdale 2025; Ellis and Stimson 2012; Fiorina et al. 2004).

Past work examines issue attitudes’ potential to induce political realignment (Carmines and Stimson 1989), their relationship to partisan polarization (Abramowitz 2018; Iyengar et al. 2019; Mason 2018), and what role they play in candidate evaluation (Bullock 2011; Lenz 2012; Ryan and Ehlinger 2023; Velez and Liu 2025). We depart from this work by examining how issue opinions bear on citizens’ ability to persuade each other. We hypothesize that atypical issue arguments—arguments where the speaker endorses a policy opinion that deviates from the norms for the arguer’s party, as with Arthur’s case above—might have distinctive persuasive effects.

We posit two distinct reasons atypical arguments might have distinctive effects. First, such

arguments represent expectancy violations (Burgoon et al. 2016)—departures from learned patterns of behavior that attract particular interest and attention from those who see them. In Arthur’s example, it is surprising—and perhaps beneficial for Arthur’s credibility—that an avowed Trump supporter would articulate an impassioned case for same-sex marriage. Second, atypical political arguments might, as a tendency, contain different content than typical arguments. Consider that Arthur’s argument grounds his support for same-sex marriage in views on individual freedom—a value that a liberal proponent of same-sex marriage might be less likely to center.

Here, we examine atypical arguments and their potentially distinct influence in citizen persuasion efforts. To begin, we collect arguments from individuals (termed Senders) who sincerely hold party-typical and -atypical policy opinions. We examine the content of these arguments and find evidence that they differ in both style and substance. Next, we present results from an experiment designed to consider the persuasive effects of atypicality and, furthermore, to locate these effects within the expectancy and content-grounded mechanisms we discuss above. We present Senders’ arguments to other individuals (termed Receivers), experimentally manipulating whether or not the partisan identity of the argument’s author is visible. Because expectancy violations—but not mechanisms grounded in message substance—hinge on a message recipient knowing elements of the argument author’s background, this design feature allows us to evaluate the relative importance of the two mechanisms we describe above.

Our results show that atypical arguments differ both substantively and stylistically from typical ones. Furthermore, we find that Receivers considering arguments in a persuasion-focused context perceive typical and atypical arguments as differently compelling. Atypical arguments arising from the Receiver’s out-party are perceived to be more compelling than typical arguments, while atypical arguments arising from the Receiver’s in-party are perceived to be less compelling than typical arguments. These patterns arise even when analytically controlling for whether or not an argument challenges a Receiver’s existing attitudes. Furthermore, these effects arise most clearly when the author’s partisan identity is hidden, implying that differences in what atypical arguers write—rather than expectancy violations—cause their arguments to be received differently.

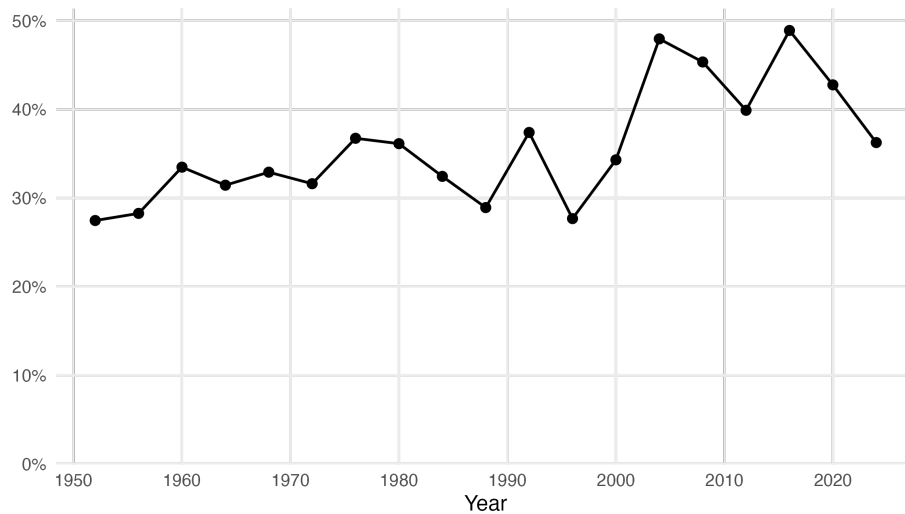
As we discuss in our concluding section, these results underline regular citizens’ potential to engage

in effective political persuasion—especially citizens who are sufficiently independent-minded to depart from the stances that are typical for their party.

CITIZENS PERSUADING CITIZENS

Citizens commonly attempt to influence each others' political views. Although scholars have long recognized this reality (Huckfeldt et al. 1995; Lazarsfeld et al. 1944), citizen-initiated persuasion efforts might be more common than they used to be. Figure 1 reports the proportion of ANES respondents, for presidential elections going back to 1952, reporting that they tried to show another person “why they should vote for or against one of the parties or candidates.” The figure reveals a noticeable uptick starting in 2004, possibly coinciding with the advent of social media (albeit with a decline in 2024).

Citizen-initiated political influence attempts raise theoretical considerations that elite-driven political influence does not. For instance, it would make little sense to examine politicians' personality traits as predictors of their persuasiveness: Elite-driven messaging runs largely through professional strategists, making the relationship a *non sequitur*. Citizen-initiated persuasion, on the other hand, is often unfiltered and unscripted—as when a person makes an extemporaneous remark while standing around the water cooler with coworkers. As such, personality traits might have a clearer correspondence to a person's persuasive influence—and so they do (Naunov et al. 2025). Of importance for the present work, citizen-initiated influence is not disciplined by a broader party apparatus. Political elites, such as members of Congress, face strong disincentives to deviate from a centrally coordinated party “brand”—even if the brand does not do well representing all of a member's policy views (Aldrich 1995). Regular citizens do not have such an incentive. In fact, signs of political independence generally appear to increase a person's social esteem in the eyes of others (Klar and Krupnikov 2015). These realities motivate us to examine the dynamics that come into play within the ecosystem of citizen-centric persuasion.

FIGURE 1. Proportion of Citizens Engaged in Persuasion

Note: Source: ANES Cumulative File, variable VCF0717. Weighted estimates.

ATYPICAL ARGUMENTS

We define an atypical argument as one where the argument author endorses a policy position that deviates from the norms for the arguer's party. We posit two reasons that atypical arguments might influence recipients differently than typical arguments. First, such arguments can cause expectancy violations—departures from expected behavior that lead the argument to be considered in different terms than typical arguments. Second, typical and atypical arguments might differ in their actual content. We discuss each possibility in turn.

Expectancy mechanisms

People approach communicative interactions with expectations about what will be said and whether the interaction will be positive or negative. When these expectations are violated, an expectancy violation occurs (Burgoon 1993; Burgoon et al. 2016). Expectancy violations motivate a listener to pay more attention to the communication than they otherwise would. For instance, Maheswaran and Chaiken (1991) show that evaluations that depart from a group consensus are more memorable and more influential than evaluations that mirror the consensus position.

The effects of expectancy violations likely depend on whether the communication is initially expected to be favorable or unfavorable toward one's group. If a communication expected to be favorable turns unfavorable, the departure is a *negative* expectancy violation. Negative expectancy violations are associated with greater scrutiny and harsher evaluation of the communication (Burgoon 1993; Eidelman and Biernat 2003; Marques and Paez 1994). A communication expected to be unfavorable that turns favorable, in contrast, is a *positive* expectancy violation. Positive expectancy violations are associated with receptivity (Burgoon et al. 2016) and imparting greater credibility to the communicator (Floyd and Voloudakis 1999). In this vein, Yamamoto & Chang (2025) find that source-inconsistent headlines (e.g. Fox News coverage that expresses concerns about climate change) improve feelings toward the news source.

While expectancies and expectancy violations can arise from many sources, one that is of particular political relevance is partisanship. Partisan identities strongly establish communicative expectations, both because partisanship is an important social identity (Green et al. 2002) and because it is a strong proxy for an array of other politically relevant identities (Mason 2018).

Content mechanisms

Atypical arguments could be differently influential than typical arguments even in the absence of expectancy violations. The same psychological factors that induce people to hold atypical political views could also lead to differences in how those views are expressed. Thus, typical and atypical arguments might contain systematically different content, which could lead to differences in how they are perceived.

We consider two ways in which the content of typical and atypical arguments could differ. First, these arguments could differ in the substantive considerations they raise.³ For instance, consider a Republican who, departing from what is typical for his party, supports higher gasoline taxes. Such a person might substantiate their opinion by referencing the potential for gasoline taxes to shrink governmental budget deficits. A Democrat listening to this person might also favor higher gasoline taxes, but for different reasons, such as being concerned with climate change. As such, the Democrat

³See Gilens (2001) on the influence of policy-specific facts.

could encounter new, not-yet-considered reasons to favor gasoline taxes.

Typical and atypical arguments could also differ with respect to their style. For instance, if the motivation for an arguer to deviate from their party's line arises from open-mindedness or from broad exposure to reasoning on both sides of a policy proposal, it could lead arguers to state views in more nuanced, caveated, or circumspect ways. Such stylistic differences can markedly change how political communication lands, even in the absence of substantive differences (Cesario and Higgins 2008; Mutz and Reeves 2005; Tenney et al. 2008; Ryan and Krupnikov 2021). Therefore, we attend to both substantive and stylistic differences in the content of typical and atypical arguments.

Content and expectancy mechanisms are not mutually exclusive. Both could operate simultaneously, and potentially reinforce each other. However, expectancy mechanisms require the person considering an argument to know or infer information about the argument's source—a property we exploit in the experiment we describe below.

SENDERS' INSTRUMENT

Our study has two parts. In the first, which we call the Senders' instrument, we recruited participants to provide sincere arguments on a set of policies. In the second, the Receivers' instrument, we presented a subset of these arguments to different participants to assess their persuasive effects. We describe the Senders' instrument here.

Participants. Participants (N=621) were undergraduates who completed the study as a means of fulfilling a course requirement. This portion of the study was fielded in October, 2023.

While reliance on a student sample limits our ability to generalize to the United States population, the analyses that follow do not aim to characterize what proportion of Americans hold atypical issue positions. Rather, we seek to examine how issue arguments differ between individuals with typical and atypical views. Additionally, a student sample provides high compliance with an effortful writing task—compliance that can be difficult to achieve in national samples (Douglas et al. 2023; Stagnaro et al. 2026).

Questionnaire. The Senders' Instrument began with a series of questions measuring attributes we thought might moderate atypicality effects: We measured partisanship, political interest, affective

polarization, and political knowledge using standard batteries. (We report all question wording in SI Section 2.) Next, Senders were asked their opinion about four specific policy proposals. They were asked whether they favor or oppose 1) ending the sale of new gas-powered cars and trucks by 2035 (the Green policy), 2) allowing teachers and school officials to carry guns in K-12 schools (the Gun policy), 3) building new nuclear power plants to generate power in the United States (the Nuclear policy), and 4) sending American ships and troops to help defend Taiwan, if China were to invade Taiwan (the Taiwan policy). Our purpose in choosing these four policies was to include two (the Green and Gun policies) where respondent policy positions would mostly fall along party lines, and two (Nuclear and Taiwan) where the party/policy stance correlations would be lower. Policy attitudes were measured on an eleven-point scale ranging from 0 (strongly oppose) to 10 (strongly favor).

Persuasion task. After giving their opinion on each of the four policies, Senders were invited to write an argument that might persuade someone who disagreed with them on a particular policy to move their opinion on the policy toward the Sender’s opinion.⁴ To incentivize the Senders to take the task seriously, the instructions for this task indicated that respondents would increase their chances to win a \$100 gift card each time their argument persuaded a future survey respondent to move their policy attitude in the intended direction. Senders were subsequently rewarded as described.

Next, participants proceeded through four screens—one for each policy—wherein they could submit persuasive arguments. The instructions for each policy reminded the Sender of their previously stated policy position and instructed them to compose an argument between 50 and 300 words long. (A continuously updated word count appeared on the screen to help Senders gauge length.) After completing the writing task, respondents were asked how much they enjoyed the task and how much effort they put into it. Participants were then thanked, provided an opportunity to give feedback, debriefed, and dismissed.

Vetting and selecting arguments. We followed a pre-registered plan to exclude arguments that were outside the length specifications (N=515 arguments), that contained profane or offense language (N=7), or that explicitly revealed the author’s partisanship (N=8). We additionally excluded 108

⁴Participants with neutral opinions on a policy were not invited to write arguments for that policy, as they could not sincerely argue for either side.

TABLE 1. Senders' Issue Positions by Party

Issue	Republicans			Democrats		
	Conservative	Liberal	Neutral	Conservative	Liberal	Neutral
Green	52.45	29.41	18.14	12.88	74.81	12.31
Gun	44.17	44.17	11.65	3.59	93.01	3.40
Nuclear	51.23	19.70	29.06	44.68	31.75	23.57
Taiwan	55.67	27.09	17.24	54.98	27.20	17.82

Note: We classify the following policy stances as conservative: opposing EV mandates (Green); favoring teachers carrying guns (Gun); favoring nuclear energy expansion (Nuclear); favoring military intervention to aid Taiwan (Taiwan).

arguments that showed unanticipated issues.⁵ These exclusions left us with 1717 arguments across 4 policies.

EXAMINING ARGUMENT CONTENT

Table 1 shows Senders' policy positions, broken down by partisanship and by policy area. For instance, 52.45% of Republican Senders adopted a conservative position on the Green policy. This table confirms that, in the context of specific, concrete policy proposals, policy opinions depart from partisan identities in notable ways. Among Senders, the median percentage supporting a party-atypical position is 28.2%.

The content-grounded mechanisms we discuss above require typical and atypical arguments to differ in their content. Our impressionistic review of these arguments suggested that they do. To illustrate the kinds of differences we noticed, Table 2 presents two arguments that were submitted in our study. While not randomly chosen, they help illustrate the kinds of differences we noticed as we reviewed the arguments Senders submitted. Both Senders argue against electric vehicle mandates—but in notably different ways. The left-hand argument, which was written by a Republican and would be classified as typical, grounds the conclusion in government “overreach” and effects on the economy—considerations that we suspect are common among EV opponents. The right-hand argument, which was written by a

⁵The most common issue was Senders engaging in “response substitution” (Graham and Yair 2023)—providing an argument about a policy other than the one we asked about. For instance, a sender explaining their opinion about allowing teachers to carry guns wrote, “I put a two because I think there should be an armed officer on campus, but I strongly oppose teachers having guns in the classroom.”

Democrat and would be classified as atypical, grounds the conclusion in environmental effects and human rights—considerations that we suspect are more novel among EV opponents.

TABLE 2. Example Anti-EV arguments

The end of the sale of gas powered vehicles presents several problems. One being that the government gains an unnecessary amount of power and overreach in the economy. This also may present challenges in the traditional economy that revolves around gas powered vehicles. This includes certain businesses that supply the gasoline or the gas powered vehicles.	The mining of lithium batteries has just as harsh an impact on the environment as gas-powered cars. The process of obtaining the power for electric vehicles is highly destructive and often violates many human rights in the process. Instead, we should focus on increasing and improving public transit systems and city infrastructure.
<i>Written by a Republican (typical)</i>	<i>Written by a Democrat (atypical)</i>

To move beyond impressionistic accounts, we conducted a content analysis comparing typical and atypical arguments. We focus this analysis on the Green and Gun policies. As we note above, these policies were chosen because perceptions about the typical party positions are clear-cut: Democrats typically favor green energy policies and Republicans oppose them; Democrats typically favor gun control and Republicans oppose it. Including the Nuclear and Taiwan policies would require us to stipulate which side of each policy counts as the typical Democratic or Republican position—a stipulation that would be difficult to justify. (We reintroduce these policies in an analysis below by relying on individual perceptions of what stances are typical for each party.)

From the full sample of submitted arguments, we randomly selected 60 arguing the liberal position on each policy and 60 arguing the conservative position. We further stratified so that each set of 60 included 30 arguments written by Democrats and 30 by Republicans.⁶ In this way, we constructed a sample (224 arguments total) balanced across both liberal and conservative—as well as typical and atypical—arguments.

We examined the arguments in three ways. The first two focus on argument style. The last focuses on argument substance.

⁶Our sample included only 14 instances where a Democratic respondent argued the conservative position on the Gun policy. We include all 14 in this analysis.

1. We used the `Politeness` package (Yeomans et al. 2019) to systematically code each argument's Conversational Receptiveness—defined as expressed “willingness to thoughtfully engage with opposing views” (Yeomans et al. 2020). Conversational Receptiveness signals respect for the receiver and makes messages more likely to be persuasive and informative (Brown and Levinson 1987).
2. Because we were concerned that Conversational Receptiveness might not capture all the stylistic elements that seemed significant to us when we inspected the arguments, we developed an original coding approach to measure five language attributes that we thought might contribute to argument influence: 1) orientation toward detractors (critical vs. validating), 2) nuance, 3) ambivalence, 4) invocation of personal narratives, and 5) humility. We label the summary measure generated by summing across these elements Conciliatoriness.
3. For each of the four argument conclusions (i.e. favoring or opposing the Green and Gun policies), we identified the 6–8 most prominent substantive considerations the respondents invoked.⁷ We then hand coded whether each consideration was present or absent within each argument.

The Supporting Information (Section 3) contains details on our coding procedures and analyses. Here, we summarize the main results.

1. Typical and atypical arguments differ in Conversational Receptiveness. With Receptiveness scaled from -1 to +1, atypical arguments were 0.051 units higher in Receptiveness ($SE = 0.022$, $p < .02$) than typical arguments.
2. We found no statistically significant contrasts on the Conciliatoriness measure.
3. Since each policy-side (e.g. people arguing against gun control) might engage a different range of substantive considerations, we examine each policy-side individually. We employ Pillai's trace method (Renchner and Christensen 2012), which tests whether, within a policy-side,

⁷For instance, for the liberal side of the Gun policy, the six considerations were teachers' ability to handle firearms, normalization of gun violence, inadequacy of other policies, secure storage considerations, effects on learning, and complications during an active shooter incident.

typical and atypical arguments differ across the full set of substantive considerations. We find a statistically significant difference within one of the four policy-sides we examine: the set of arguments arguing in favor of EV adoption ($F=2.56$, $p<.04$). We also find a suggestive contrast within a second policy-side: the set of arguments arguing against teachers carrying firearms ($F=2.15$, $p<.07$). The contrasts within the remaining two policy-sides were not significant.

Considered as a whole, these results suggest that typical and atypical arguments differ in both style and substance, though the differences are not uniform across topics—a pattern future work should investigate. For now, however, we move on to compare the persuasive effects of typical and atypical arguments.

HYPOTHESES

We consider two *ex ante* hypotheses concerning the persuasive effect of atypical arguments.⁸ First, at the simplest level, we hypothesize that atypical arguments are more persuasive than typical arguments (the Atypicality Hypothesis).

Second, we consider the distinction between expectancy- and content-grounded mechanisms. Expectancy-grounded mechanisms require an argument recipient to know—or at least infer—identity elements of the argument’s author. To return to our opening example, for Arthur’s same-sex marriage argument’s persuasiveness to hinge on expectancy, the reader needs to know that Arthur wrote it and to perceive why he is a surprising source for such a statement. In contrast, content-grounded mechanisms do not require the argument recipient to have information about the author: Arthur’s argument might be influential because of what he says—not because of who Arthur is. Of course, the mechanisms are not mutually exclusive; both could operate to different degrees.

In what follows, we leverage an observable implication of this difference by presenting Senders’ arguments to new participants and randomizing whether information about the Sender is present or

⁸Our pre-registration for this study is available in the Supporting Information (SI Section 1). Our hypotheses as stated here refine the language of our pre-registered predictions in light of theoretical developments during the project.

absent. To the extent atypical arguments' different persuasiveness arises from expectancy violations, we expect these differences to arise whether Sender information is present, but to diminish when Sender information is absent (the Expectancy Hypothesis). On the other hand, to the extent atypical arguments' different persuasiveness arises from content-grounded mechanisms, we expect the differences to persist irrespective of whether Sender information is present or absent (the Content Hypothesis).

After data collection, we began to consider that the effects of atypical arguments would depend on whether they arise from a receiver's in-party or out-party. As the previous section shows, atypical arguments are more conversationally receptive and, on some policies, invoke systematically different substantive considerations than typical arguments. When arguments arise from the in-party, the mismatch between a familiar conclusion but unfamiliar reasoning can register as deviance—an argument endorsing a favored conclusion, but in a discordant way. The argument in Table 2, written by a Democrat opposing EV adoption on grounds of human rights, is illustrative: a Democratic Receiver might find the invocation jarring or off-putting even if the conclusion is congenial. Within Psychology, research on “black sheep” effects documents a similar dynamic: Deviance from ingroup norms is punished harshly (Eidelman and Biernat 2003).

For out-party arguments, the logic reverses. Typical out-party arguments might invoke considerations the Receiver has likely encountered—and dismissed—before. Atypical out-party arguments, by contrast, might raise considerations that fall outside the Receiver's stereotyped image of what the other side says. They would be harder to reconcile with rehearsed partisan scripts, and correspondingly harder to dismiss. To return to our opening example, a Democrat reading Arthur's case for same-sex marriage in the vocabulary of freedom and personal liberty encounters a line of reasoning that does not fit the template of “things conservatives say”—and so has less of the usual scaffolding with which to reject it.

This line of reasoning led us to conjecture that atypicality has opposite effects on in-party and out-party arguments: Atypical in-party arguments are less persuasive than typical ones, while atypical out-party arguments are more persuasive than typical ones (the *ex post* Asymmetric Atypicality Hypothesis).

RECEIVER'S INSTRUMENT

The canonical approach for studying source effects in political science is to present someone with a political argument, hold its content constant, and to randomly assign the source to which it is attributed. (See Druckman 2022 for a review.) This approach would be inadequate to our objectives: our interest in distinguishing expectancy- from content-grounded mechanisms requires us to examine arguments whose content was authentically produced by people holding typical and atypical opinions, as we describe next.

Participants. Participants (N=536) were undergraduates who completed the study to fulfill a course requirement; the study was fielded in March and April of 2024. As in the Senders' instrument, we rely on a student sample because the question motivating this study—how readers respond to typical versus atypical arguments—depends on participants actually engaging with the arguments they are asked to evaluate. Detecting differences in response requires sustained reading attention, and student samples reliably provide it; nationally representative online panels, by contrast, frequently produce low-attention pass-throughs on text-heavy stimuli (Douglas et al. 2023; Stagnaro et al. 2026). We leave a separate question—which sampling frame best supports inferences about the systemic effects of atypical arguments—to future work.

Pre-treatment questions. The Receivers' instrument began by presenting the same four policy proposals that the Senders saw. After recording Receivers' opinions, we measured typicality perceptions by asking, for each policy, whether they think the typical Democrat and Republican favors or opposes the proposal (separate questions for each party—eight in total across all four policies).

Atypicality randomization. To begin, we extended the process (described above) for creating a balanced sample of typical and atypical arguments to the Nuclear and Taiwan policies. This process generated 236 arguments which, added to the 224 arguments analyzed above, resulted in 460 total arguments⁹ that would be presented to Receivers.

Next, Receivers were presented with two arguments for each policy proposal. The order of the policies was randomized. For each policy, Receivers were assigned to evaluate arguments 1) on

⁹There were only 26 anti-nuclear arguments from Republicans, explaining the shortfall compared to the expected total of 240.

the liberal or the conservative side of each policy, and 2) coming from Democratic or Republican authors.¹⁰ Once the argument type was established (e.g. liberal arguments coming from Republicans), two arguments—chosen at random from among those of that type—were presented to the Receiver. Because argument type was re-randomized for each policy, respondents could evaluate both typical and atypical—as well as in-party and out-party—arguments as they proceeded from one policy to the next. Because each presented argument was drawn at random from a pool of approximately 30 of its type, any observed persuasion effects reflect general differences between argument types rather than the influence of any single argument.

Author information randomization. Additionally, Receivers were randomly assigned, between subjects, to know the partisanship of the Sender who wrote each argument they read—or not to know this information. We informed respondents about Sender partisanship via a single sentence that appeared prominently below each argument text: “This explanation was written by a respondent who identifies as a [Republican / Democrat].” This sentence always correctly described the Sender’s partisanship; for Receivers assigned to the no-information condition, it was simply absent. We randomized author information between subjects, rather than between policies: in the latter approach, Receivers would likely notice the manipulation, raising concerns about demand effects.

After reading two arguments for a particular issue, we measured two outcomes: post-argument policy attitude and compellingness. For policy attitude, Receivers once again placed themselves on the same zero to ten favor/oppose scale that they saw at the start of the instrument. For compellingness, respondents indicated how compelling they found the reasoning in each argument to be, on a four-point scale ranging from “not compelling at all” to “very compelling.” Naturally, policy attitudes were measured just once per policy. Compellingness, however, was measured once per argument (twice per policy), for a total of eight evaluations across the four policies. Work in communication finds perceived message effectiveness is a leading indicator of persuasion (Dillard et al. 2007; Noar et al. 2020), consistent with the theoretical idea that, under conditions of careful processing, perceptions of argument quality precede persuasion (Petty and Cacioppo 1986). For these reasons, and because it

¹⁰For purposes of randomization, we stipulated the following positions to be liberal: favoring fuel regulations, opposing teachers having guns in school, opposing nuclear power plant construction, and opposing military intervention in Taiwan.

is measured more frequently, we treat compellingness as our primary outcome in what follows. The attitude measure, in contrast, yielded few significant contrasts—a pattern consistent with the broader finding that attitude change is difficult—especially when respondents have explicitly committed to an initial policy position that shapes the considerations available for subsequent reports (Tourangeau et al. 1989). We report these results in the Supporting Information (Section 4.4).

Estimation approach. Our core estimation approach is

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Compelling} = & \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Atypical} + \beta_2 \text{OutParty} + \beta_3 \text{Atypical} \times \text{OutParty} \\ & + \beta_4 \text{Congruent} + \beta_5 \text{Incongruent} + \beta_{6,7,8} \text{Policy} + \gamma_{\text{Receivers}} + \zeta_{\text{Arguments}} + \epsilon. \quad (1) \end{aligned}$$

We estimate this model within our full sample of Receivers—but also within subgroups defined by the Author Information random assignment. This approach allows us to consider how the visibility or absence of Sender partisan information conditions other relationships in the model—without the complexity of triple interaction terms.

In this model, *Atypical* is a dummy variable identifying Atypical arguments. *OutParty* is a dummy variable that takes a value of 1 when the Receiver and Sender identify with the opposite political party, and 0 otherwise. *Incongruent* is a dummy variable that takes a value of 1 when the presented arguments push against the Receiver’s initial policy opinion, and 0 otherwise. *Congruent* is a dummy variable that takes a value of 1 when the presented arguments affirm the Receiver’s initial policy opinion, and 0 otherwise. (Receivers with initially neutral policy opinions represent a reference category.) *Policy* represents a series of dummy variables for each specific policy topic we study. γ and ζ represent random intercept terms for individual Receivers and individual Sender arguments, respectively.

We code the *Atypical* variable in two ways. Our “anchored” version of the variable stipulates one side of each policy to be liberal and the other to be conservative.¹¹ Our perception-grounded coding is designed to account for the reality that perceptions of party typical stances vary across respondents—especially for the two policies (Nuclear and Taiwan) that we included precisely to

¹¹Consistent with the randomization approach above, we stipulate the following stances to be liberal: favoring EV adoption, opposing teachers carrying guns, opposing nuclear energy expansion, and opposing military defense of Taiwan.

introduce such variation. The perception-grounded coding relies on the questions that Receivers answered indicating, for each policy, whether the typical Democrat (Republican) favors or opposes the policy. Under the perception-grounded coding, an argument is classified as typical (or atypical) based on whether the Receiver's own reported perceptions of party positions would lead them to view it as such.

This estimation approach deviates from our pre-registration. To assess the Asymmetric Atypicality Hypothesis, we allow atypicality effects to differ for in-party versus out-party arguments, motivating inclusion of the $\text{OutParty} \times \text{Atypical}$ term (as well as a main effect for OutParty) in Equation (1). Including these terms also necessitates including the Congruent and Incongruent terms in Equation (1), for analytical reasons we elaborate in the Supporting Information (Section 4.3). Table 16 in the Supporting Information reports our pre-registered models, for transparency.

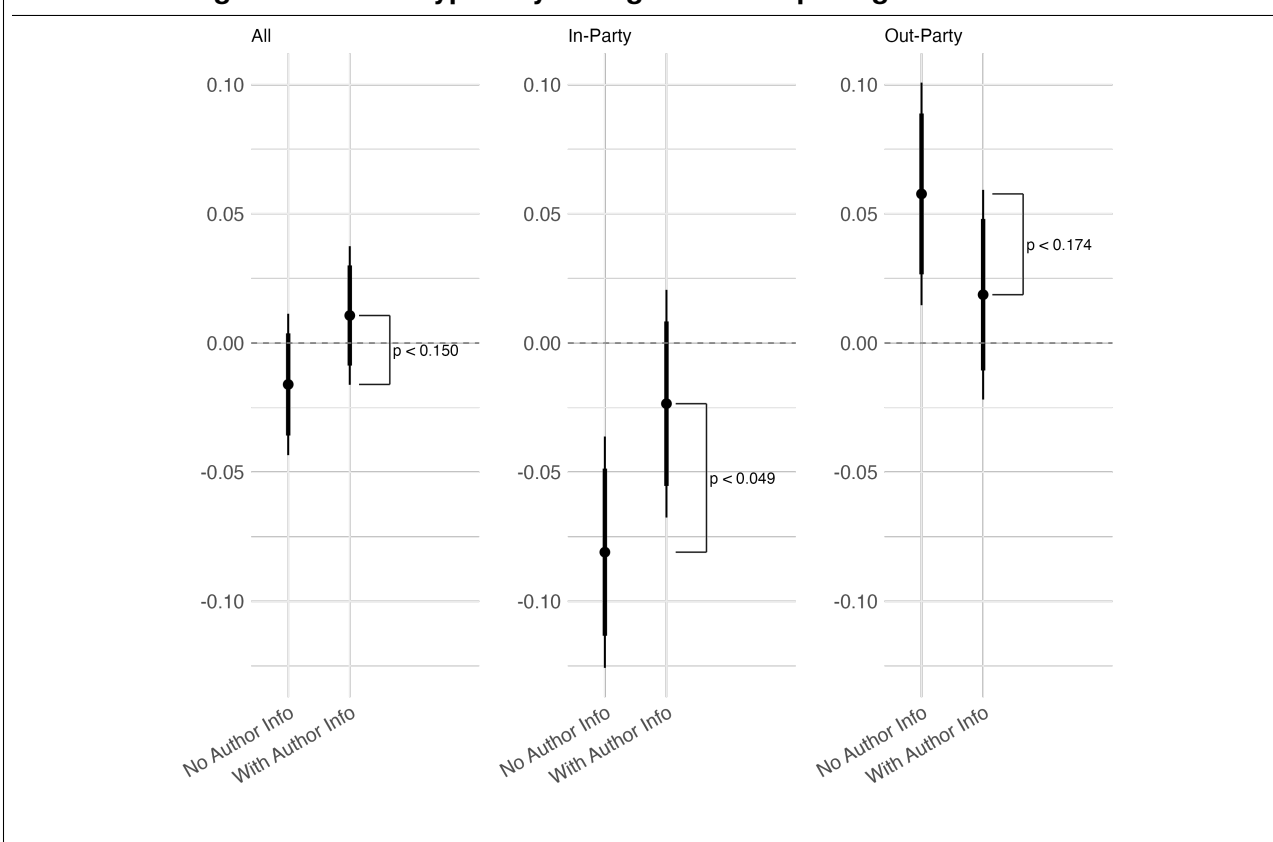
EFFECTS OF ATYPICALITY

Figure 2 plots key relationships derived from the model described above. It plots the marginal effect of perceptually Atypical arguments, separated by whether they come from the Receiver's in-party or out-party (panels), and whether author information was present or absent (divisions within panels). We report the underlying regression models in the SI (Table 14). We also report the results for the anchored version of the atypicality variable in the SI (Section 4.6). They are substantively similar.

The left panel of Figure 2 shows that, averaging across in-party and out-party arguments, atypical arguments are perceived as similarly compelling. The point estimates for without and with author info are both insignificant, and they are not statistically distinguishable from each other. (P-values within the plot come from Wald tests for equivalence of the two point estimates.)

The remaining two panels reveal that the pooled model masks differences between arguments arising from the Receiver's in-party and their out-party. When author information is hidden, atypicality harms evaluations of in-party arguments ($\text{ME} = -0.081$, $\text{SE} = 0.023$, $p < .001$) and improves evaluations of out-party arguments ($\text{ME} = 0.058$, $\text{SE} = 0.022$, $p < .01$). The analogous estimates for when author information is present are not significant (for in-party arguments, $\text{ME} = -0.023$, $\text{SE} = 0.022$, $p = .296$; for out-party arguments, $\text{ME} = 0.019$, $\text{SE} = 0.021$, $p = .367$). The contrast between author information

FIGURE 2. Marginal effect of atypicality on argument compellingness



Note: Point estimates are estimated marginal effects of atypicality (perception-grounded) on perceived argument compellingness. Within each panel, there are separate estimates for arguments originating from in-party and out-party senders. Thick bars are 84% confidence intervals. Thin bars are 95% confidence intervals. The dependent variable is scaled 0–1.

being present or absent is significant for in-party arguments ($p < .05$), but not for out-party arguments ($p = .174$). Altogether, we infer that atypicality harms the perception of in-party arguments, improves the perception of out-party arguments—and that adding author information dampens these effects.

Figure 4 in the SI presents the same results, segmented by policies. We find suggestive evidence that the significant negative effect reported in Figure 2 arises largely from the two policies that are more cleanly divided by party (Green and Gun). On the other hand, the significant positive effect in Figure 2 arises mostly from the two issues with weaker partisan divides. We return to this result in the next section.

DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSION

Our experiment shows that atypicality effects on citizen persuasion are conditional on the Sender's partisanship relative to the Receiver's, and on whether the Receiver has access to author information. Pooled across in- and out-party arguments, atypicality exerts no reliable influence on perceived compellingness (left panel of Figure 2). But, disaggregating by party shows that atypical arguments from the Receiver's out-party are perceived as *more* compelling than typical arguments, while atypical arguments from the Receiver's in-party are perceived as *less* compelling. Thus, while atypical arguments are not uniformly more compelling than typical ones (the Atypicality Hypothesis), we do find that they are *differently* compelling, in a way described by the Asymmetric Atypicality Hypothesis.

The conditions under which atypicality effects arise help to show why. If atypicality operated through expectancy violations, the contrasts should be strongest when Receivers can recognize an argument as atypical—that is, when the Sender's partisanship is visible. The opposite is true: The in-party and out-party effects both arise in the no-context condition and largely disappear once the Sender's partisanship is revealed. This pattern runs counter to the directional prediction of our Expectancy Hypothesis. It points instead toward a content-grounded account: What atypical arguers write, rather than who Receivers take them to be, carries the persuasive effect.

If the mechanism is content-grounded, why do the effects diminish once author information is added? The argument content, after all, is identical across conditions. We suspect that knowing a Sender's partisanship shifts Receivers' mental focus from one that is effortful, reflective, and focused on argument merits to one tinged by the psychology of partisan identity (see Arceneaux and Vander Wielen 2017). Receivers who are deprived of partisan shortcuts engage more deeply with content, and it is there that atypicality's distinctive effects reside. Three additional results are consistent with this explanation. First, Receivers appear to be more influenced by overall agreement or disagreement with an argument's conclusion (i.e., “congruence”) when author information is present than when it is absent (Table 14). Second, when we limit our analysis to the pure independents in our sample, we find suggestive evidence that they are immune to the dampening effect of partisan information (SI Section 4.8). Third, the in-party penalty is concentrated on the two issues with the strongest partisan divides (Green and Gun), where Receivers have the best-developed partisan schemas to bring to bear (Figure

4). While we hesitate to over-interpret with only four issues, this pattern is consistent with partisan schemas playing a role in which atypical content registers as deviant.

Several caveats bound our claims. First, we rely on undergraduate samples. While we do not expect that undergraduates exhibit a fundamentally different psychology than others (Druckman and Kam 2011), we suspect that they provided higher-quality arguments, and perhaps were better able to discern typical versus atypical considerations, than a cross section of the public would be. Second, our persuasion outcome is perceived compellingness, not attitude change. We find no effects on the attitude measure—a null consistent with the general difficulty of moving policy opinions that were expressed earlier in the same survey (Tourangeau et al. 1989), but a limitation we do not paper over. Third, we examine only written communication. This focus made it possible to systematically code message content and present it to Receivers in a tightly controlled way, but future work should examine how typicality effects arise in other modalities (e.g. videos or in-person conversations).

Our finding about the dampening effect of partisan information connects with recent work in outlining conditions under which citizen persuasion is more and less likely to succeed. Carlson and Settle 2022 show that citizens turn to a wide variety of subtle cues—names, musical tastes, food preferences, whether they prefer cats or dogs, and so forth—to infer the political leanings of the people with whom they interact. On the flip side, Klar and Krupnikov 2015 show how motivated some people are to elude such inferences, for fear of seeming overly political. Our results show what is at stake in this game of cat and mouse. When partisan information is available, political arguments that otherwise might present novel considerations and prompt the recipient to reconsider their views become easier to dismiss.

More broadly, our results point to a mechanism of mass-opinion change that is easy to miss in work focused on political elites or on partisan rigidity within the mass public. Citizens who hold party-atypical views—roughly a quarter of our Sender sample, consistent with broader evidence of weak ideological constraint—can shift how their interlocutors perceive an issue, especially when partisan identities are not foregrounded. Much citizen-to-citizen political talk occurs in precisely such settings: informal conversation among acquaintances, semi-anonymous online exchange, cross-cutting ties where partisan affiliation is inferred rather than announced. The pathway we document does not

contradict evidence that elite cues structure partisan opinion or that information environments are sorted; it operates alongside those dynamics, in the portions of citizens' political lives that are less heavily politicized. The most consequential next question is which features of everyday discourse most reliably tip exchange toward content-focused engagement.

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1 EXPERIMENT PRE-REGISTRATION

[Note: The pre-registration below alludes to “learning”- and “credibility”-grounded effects. As we note in footnote 8 in the main text, our terminology evolved as our theoretical thinking developed. The learning effects described below are equivalent to what the main text terms content-grounded effects. The credibility effects described below are subsumed within what the main text terms expectancy-grounded effects.]

There are widely-held stereotypes about what specific policy stances are more or less probable for citizens of different partisan stripes to hold. For instance, a Democrat who favors pro-choice abortion policies is more common than a Democrat who is pro-life. Of course, some people depart from such patterns. Some Democrats earnestly hold pro-life positions, and others are ambivalent about the abortion issue (Fiorina et al., 2008). Moreover, there are numerous issues for which the lines of political division are murkier than they are for abortion. The Republican Party has a long-running reputation for being more “hawkish” than the Democratic Party, but this stereotype does not map neatly onto current debates about how vigorously to support Ukraine’s resistance to Russia’s 2022 invasion, for instance. As concerns Ukraine, the Democrats are the hawks, and the Republicans are the doves.

We theorize that, when citizens attempt to influence each other’s attitudes about political issues, perceptions about the partisan typicality of the arguments being offered bear on how they are perceived and, ultimately, their persuasive force.

There are at least two distinct reasons the perceived typicality of an argument might help determine how influential it is. First, atypical arguments might present the argument recipient with ideas that are less familiar and thus do more to broaden the range of considerations that can come to mind when formulating a judgment. When the argument favors the recipient’s pre-existing opinion on an issue, this means that they could learn new, previously unconsidered reasons that their pre-existing opinion is correct and thus resolve any pre-existing ambivalence in favor of the existing leaning. For example, a Democrat who favors green energy investment because they see this investment as benefitting the environment could, upon reading a Republican’s argument in favor of green energy investment, additionally learn that such investment might help the United States compete economically with China—a novel idea for this message recipient.

Typicality might, for similar reasons, also predict persuasiveness when an argument pushes against the recipient’s pre-existing issue opinion. For instance, imagine the same Democratic respondent reading arguments against green energy investment. The Republican argument—now the typical argument—is likely to proffer considerations that have already been considered and rejected. (E.g., that climate change is exaggerated.) But the Democratic argument—now the atypical argument—might give the respondent something new to think about, such as that green energy policies can be regressive (disproportionately affecting low-income citizens).

However, typicality effects might be transmitted through mechanisms other than learning new considerations. The second reason that the perceived typicality of an argument might help determine how influential it will be concerns how typicality bears on perceived credibility of the argument sender. People who offer atypical arguments might be perceived as more credible than those who offer typical arguments. Such arguments implicitly mean that the argument sender is “going out on a limb”—taking a stance that could put them at odds with their own political identity group. As such, these senders might be perceived as more independent-minded, more intelligent, and less beholden to their partisan team.

As such we expect:

Atypicality hypothesis: Atypical arguments—those where the argument author deviates from the recipient’s perceived norms for a particular party—are more persuasive than typical arguments.

TABLE 3. Random Assignment

	Liberal argument	Conservative argument
Democratic sender	Typical	Atypical
Republican sender	Atypical	Typical

One noteworthy aspect of the two mechanisms we describe above is that the second of them, focused on credibility, hinges on the argument recipient knowing the partisanship of the argument's author. (Without such knowledge, there is no basis on which to know that the author is deviating from the party line.) In contrast, the first mechanism focused on learning new considerations does not rely on knowing the author's partisanship. As such, our experiment includes an attribute designed to distinguish these mechanisms. To the extent that atypicality bolsters persuasion via the learning of new considerations, we expect:

Learning hypothesis: Atypical arguments are more persuasive than typical arguments, even in the absence of contextual information about the author.

On the other hand, to the extent that atypicality bolsters persuasion via its implications for sender credibility, we expect:

Credibility hypothesis: In the absence of author contextual information, atypical arguments are not more persuasive than typical arguments. But, adding contextual information increases arguments' persuasive force.

Design

We plan to conduct a 2x2x2 experiment, randomizing 1) typicality of the arguments receivers consider, 2) whether or not the partisanship of an argument author is known to the argument receiver, and 3) whether respondents consider arguments written by Democrats or Republicans. Clearly, the first two factors are critical for assessing our hypotheses. Table 3 clarifies that the third factor is essential to consider typicality effects in a way disentangled from author partisanship and message content. Without randomizing party of the sender, the typicality of arguments would be perfectly collinear with the directionality of the argument (liberal or conservative), which would leave us ill-equipped to distinguish typicality effects from one flavor of ideological argument being more persuasive than the other. (This discussion puts aside the reality that individual respondents might perceive a typical argument as atypical. For instance, a specific respondent could wrongly see Democrats opposing green energy investment as typical, when in fact this issue stance would be atypical. Randomizing partisanship of the sender as we discuss above is still necessary to create separation between genuine—not perceived—typicality of an argument and the argument's liberal/conservative lean.)

Other considerations

As we note above, the lines of party typicality are more clearly delineated for some issues than for others. An important attribute of our research design is that we present an array of issues that vary in this respect. This feature will allow us to consider how typicality effects differ, depending on how “consolidated” a political issue is, where “consolidation” refers to more uniform stereotypes about which side of an issue Democrats and Republicans adhere to. On net, we expect stronger typicality effects for consolidated than non-consolidate issues. However, our experiment also measures, pre-treatment, perceived typicality for each issue at the individual level, and we expect these measures to help us localize among respondents who actually perceive different stances as more or less typical.

Planned analyses

For our persuasion analysis, we will scale our issue opinion variables such that high values represent the sender's preferred position on each issue. To evaluate the Atypicality hypothesis, we will estimate:

$$\text{Issue_opinion_post} = B_0 + B_1 * \text{Issue_opinion_pre} + B_2 * \text{Atypical} + e,$$

where the Atypical variable is defined by the recipient's perceptions about what stances are typical for each party.

To evaluate the Learning and Credibility hypotheses, we will estimate:

$$\text{Issue_opinion_post} = B_0 + B_1 * \text{Issue_opinion_pre} + B_2 * \text{Atypical} + B_3 * \text{Context} + B_4 * \text{Atypical} * \text{Context} + e,$$

where Context is a dummy variable capturing assignment to the Context condition. Strictly interpreted, the Learning Hypothesis predicts that B_2 will be large and that B_4 will be near zero, while the Credibility Hypothesis predicts that B_4 will capture most of the effect of Atypicality and that B_2 will be near zero. Of course, our results might reveal that both posited mechanisms occur in a mixture.

We plan to conduct both by-issue analyses and a pooled analysis where all issues are combined within respondents. The latter models will include random intercepts for respondents and for specific argument combinations presented to respondents, as well as fixed effects for each of our four issues.

We also plan to conduct analyses focused on how compelling individual arguments are perceived to be. The basic form for these analyses will be:

$$\text{Compelling} = B_0 + B_1 * \text{Atypical} + B_2 * \text{Context} + B_3 * \text{Atypical} * \text{Context} + e.$$

Because the dependent variable in these analyses is measured twice per issue, the pooled models can include random intercepts for individual arguments, rather than for argument pairs.

Where our hypotheses have a directional implication for relationships in the models above, we plan to use a one-tailed hypothesis test.

Additional analyses

We also plan to examine the following relationships, though we are posing them as research questions without directional expectations.

- - Does the respondents' strength of partisanship have any bearing on persuasion or persuasive capabilities?
- - How do typicality perceptions bear on expected liking of argument authors and desire to engage in conversation with them?
- - Does sensitivity to context and typicality depend on respondents' level of political knowledge?
- - Similarly, though distinctly, does affective polarization have any bearing on persuasion or persuasive capabilities?
- - Does respondents' confidence in the typical and atypical party stances on the four political issues moderate the effects of perceived typicality on persuasion?
- - Does the strength of conviction in respondents' policy stance moderate persuasion or persuasive capabilities?

References for pre-registration

Fiorina, Morris P, Samuel A Abrams, and Jeremy C Pope. 2008. "Polarization in the American Public: Misconceptions and Misreadings." *The Journal of Politics* 70(2): 556–60.

2 QUESTION WORDING

Questions asked in both Waves 1 and 2

Partisanship: “Generally speaking, do you usually think of yourself as a Democrat, a Republican, an Independent, or what?”

- Democrat
- Republican
- Independent
- No preference
- Other party (specify)

Branched Partisanship:

1. (If R chose “Republican”/“Democrat”) Would you call yourself a strong Republican/Democrat or a not very strong Republican/Democrat?
 - Strong
 - Not very strong
2. (If R did not choose “Republican”/“Democrat”) Do you think of yourself as CLOSER to the Republican Party or the Democratic Party?
 - Closer to Republican
 - Closer to Democratic
 - Neither

Check: Do you happen to know in what year the Supreme Court of the United States decided the case Geer v. Connecticut? (Enter your best guess.)

Check follow-up: (If R correctly entered 1896) You are right! Did you look up the answer to that question, or did you already know it yourself?

- I already knew it
- I looked it up

Initial Policy Preferences:

1. **Green energy issue:** As you may know, some people think the government should provide incentives for car companies to produce and sell “green” automobiles. Under one proposal, the sale of new gas-powered cars and trucks would end entirely by 2035. Do you favor this proposal, or do you oppose it?
 - Ending the sale of new gas-powered cars and trucks by 2035
 - Response format is a sliding scale from 0-10, with 0 labeled as “Strongly oppose this policy,” 10 labeled as “Strongly favor this policy,” and 5 labeled as “Neither favor nor oppose this policy.”
2. **Gun issue:** Do you favor allowing teachers and school officials to carry guns in K-12 schools, or do you oppose this?
 - Allowing teachers and school officials to carry guns in K-12 schools

Similar response format

3. **Nuclear energy issue:** Do you favor building new nuclear power plants to generate power in the United States, or do you oppose this?

- Building new nuclear power plants to generate power in the United States

Similar response format

4. **Taiwan issue:** As you likely know, China claims the island of Taiwan as its own territory—but Taiwan claims itself to be independent of China and is an important ally of the United States. Suppose China invaded Taiwan, as some people think could happen. If this occurred, would you favor the United States sending American ships and troops to help defend Taiwan, or would you oppose this?

- Sending American ships and troops to help defend Taiwan, if China invaded Taiwan

Similar response format

Questions only asked in Wave 1 (October 2023)

Open-ended Introduction: In the remainder of this questionnaire is an activity that provides an opportunity to receive real money. Here is how this works. We are about to ask you about your reasons for the issue opinions you expressed earlier in this questionnaire. We will ask you to write a few sentences explaining each opinion. (We will skip issues for which you did not express an opinion.) In the coming weeks, we will present these responses to other survey respondents, and we will ask their opinions about the same issues. You earn one point each time someone who initially disagreed with you on a particular issue shifts their opinion one scale interval toward your preferred opinion. For instance, suppose you favor building new nuclear power plants in the U.S. and your response is shown to someone who opposes building new nuclear power plants in the U.S. (initially offering an opinion of 2 on our 0-10 response scale). If this respondent changed their opinion to 3 after reading your argument, you would earn one point. Points are similar to raffle tickets: each one earns you one entry into a drawing. In the future, we will conduct a drawing for five \$100 prizes. The selected participants will each receive a \$100 gift card for Amazon.com. Please press the “next” button when you are ready to continue.

Open-ended questions:

1. **Green energy:** Earlier in this survey, you said that you $\{e://Field/i1fo\}$ the proposal where the sale of new gas-powered cars and trucks would end entirely by 2035. In the space below, please explain your reasons for this opinion. As we stated previously, responses that persuade people who disagree with you to move toward your opinion on this issue increase your chances of receiving a \$100 gift card. Note that we can only present responses that are between 50 and 300 words long. To be eligible for the gift card drawing, please keep your response between 50 and 300 words.
 - Word count displayed to respondents: “Your word count is: XX”
2. **Guns:** Earlier in this survey, you said that you $\{e://Field/i2fo\}$ allowing teachers and school officials to carry guns in K-12 schools. In the space below, please explain your reasons for this opinion. As we stated previously, responses that persuade people who disagree with you to move toward your opinion on this issue increase your chances of receiving a \$100 gift card.

Note that we can only present responses that are between 50 and 300 words long. To be eligible for the gift card drawing, please keep your response between 50 and 300 words.

- Word count displayed to respondents: “Your word count is: XX”
3. **Nuclear energy:** Earlier in this survey, you said that you $\{e://Field/i3fo\}$ building new nuclear power plants to generate power in the United States. In the space below, please explain your reasons for this opinion. As we stated previously, responses that persuade people who disagree with you to move toward your opinion on this issue increase your chances of receiving a \$100 gift card. Note that we can only present responses that are between 50 and 300 words long. To be eligible for the gift card drawing, please keep your response between 50 and 300 words.
 - Word count displayed to respondents: “Your word count is: XX”
 4. **Taiwan:** Earlier in this survey, you said that you $\{e://Field/i4fo\}$ the United States sending American ships and troops to help defend Taiwan. In the space below, please explain your reasons for this opinion. As we stated previously, responses that persuade people who disagree with you to move toward your opinion on this issue increase your chances of receiving a \$100 gift card. Note that we can only present responses that are between 50 and 300 words long. To be eligible for the gift card drawing, please keep your response between 50 and 300 words.
 - Word count displayed to respondents: “Your word count is: XX”

Questions only asked in Wave 2 (March/April 2024)

Typicality perceptions:

1. **Green energy:** Again, some people think the government should provide incentives for car companies to produce and sell “green” automobiles. Under one proposal, the sale of new gas-powered cars and trucks would end entirely by 2035. When it comes to **Republicans[Democrats]**, do you think the typical **Republican[Democrat]** favors this proposal, or do you think they oppose this?
 - Favors / Opposes / Don’t know
2. **Guns:** When it comes to **Republicans[Democrats]**, do you think the typical **Republican[Democrat]** favors allowing teachers and school officials to carry guns in K-12 schools, or do you think they oppose this?
 - Favors / Opposes / Don’t know
3. **Nuclear energy:** When it comes to **Republicans[Democrats]**, do you think the typical **Republican[Democrat]** in the United States, or do you think they oppose this?
 - Favors / Opposes / Don’t know
4. **Taiwan:** Again, China claims the island of Taiwan as its own territory—but Taiwan claims itself to be independent of China and is an important ally of the United States. Suppose China invaded Taiwan, as some people think could happen within a few years. If this occurred, do you think the typical **Republican[Democrat]** would favor the United States sending American ships and troops to help defend Taiwan, or do you think they would oppose this?
 - Favors / Opposes / Don’t know

Argument Introduction: Earlier in this survey, you offered your opinion about four political topics. Last semester, we asked other UNC students (maybe even you) to explain their opinions about these topics. In the screens that follow, you will see some of the explanations that students wrote. Please read them carefully, and then answer the questions that follow. As a reminder, this survey does not rely on any deception. We have not fact checked the explanations themselves, but any information you see about the authors' background is true. Press the arrow button to continue.

1. **Green energy arguments:** Please read the following arguments about environmental regulation and then answer the questions that follow.

- Proposition: The United States should end the sale of gas-powered cars and trucks by 2035.
 - **Explanation #1:** \${e://Field/green_arg1}
 - * (If **with context**) This explanation was written by a respondent who identifies as a **Republican/Democrat**.
 - **Explanation #2:** \${e://Field/green_arg2}
 - * (If **with context**) This explanation was written by a respondent who identifies as a **Republican/Democrat**.
- Having read the explanations above, where would you place yourself on the 10-point scale you saw earlier? Remember, you should place yourself at 0 or 10 only if your feelings about this issue are extremely intense.
 - Ending the sale of new gas-powered cars and trucks by 2035
 - * Response format is a sliding scale from 0-10, with 0 labeled as “Strongly oppose this policy,” 10 labeled as “Strongly favor this policy,” and 5 labeled as “Neither favor nor oppose this policy.”
- **New page:** As a reminder, here are the explanations you just read. Please scroll to the bottom of the page to answer another question about them.
 - **Explanation #1:** \${e://Field/green_arg1}
 - * (If **with context**) This explanation was written by a respondent who identifies as a **Republican/Democrat**.
 - **Explanation #2:** \${e://Field/green_arg2}
 - * (If **with context**) This explanation was written by a respondent who identifies as a **Republican/Democrat**.
- How compelling do you find the reasoning in each of these arguments to be?

	Not compelling at all	A little compelling	Somewhat compelling	Very compelling
Explanation #1	☐	☐	☐	☐
Explanation #2	☐	☐	☐	☐

2. **Gun arguments:** Please read the following arguments about guns in schools carefully, and then answer the questions that follow.

- Proposition: Allow teachers and school officials to carry guns in K-12 schools.
 - **Explanation #1:** \${e://Field/gun_arg1}
 - * (If **with context**) This explanation was written by a respondent who identifies as a **Republican/Democrat**.
 - **Explanation #2:** \${e://Field/gun_arg2}
 - * (If **with context**) This explanation was written by a respondent who identifies as a **Republican/Democrat**.
- Having read the explanations above, where would you place yourself on the 10-point scale you saw earlier? Remember, you should place yourself at 0 or 10 only if your feelings about this issue are extremely intense.
 - Allowing teachers and school officials to carry guns in K-12 schools
 - * Response format is a sliding scale from 0-10, with 0 labeled as “Strongly oppose this policy,” 10 labeled as “Strongly favor this policy,” and 5 labeled as “Neither favor nor oppose this policy.”
- **New page:** As a reminder, here are the explanations you just read. Please scroll to the bottom of the page to answer another question about them.
 - **Explanation #1:** \${e://Field/gun_arg1}
 - * (If **with context**) This explanation was written by a respondent who identifies as a **Republican/Democrat**.
 - **Explanation #2:** \${e://Field/gun_arg2}
 - * (If **with context**) This explanation was written by a respondent who identifies as a **Republican/Democrat**.
- How compelling do you find the reasoning in each of these arguments to be? [Similar response format]

3. **Nuclear energy arguments:** Please read the following arguments about nuclear energy carefully, and then answer the questions that follow.

- Proposition: Build new nuclear power plants in the United States.
 - **Explanation #1:** \${e://Field/nuclear_arg1}

- * (If **with context**) This explanation was written by a respondent who identifies as a **Republican/Democrat**.
- **Explanation #2:** \${e://Field/nuclear_arg2}
- * (If **with context**) This explanation was written by a respondent who identifies as a **Republican/Democrat**.
- Having read the explanations above, where would you place yourself on the 10-point scale you saw earlier? Remember, you should place yourself at 0 or 10 only if your feelings about this issue are extremely intense.
 - Building new nuclear power plants to generate power in the United States
 - * Response format is a sliding scale from 0-10, with 0 labeled as “Strongly oppose this policy,” 10 labeled as “Strongly favor this policy,” and 5 labeled as “Neither favor nor oppose this policy.”
- **New page:** As a reminder, here are the explanations you just read. Please scroll to the bottom of the page to answer another question about them.
 - **Explanation #1:** \${e://Field/nuclear_arg1}
 - * (If **with context**) This explanation was written by a respondent who identifies as a **Republican/Democrat**.
 - **Explanation #2:** \${e://Field/nuclear_arg2}
 - * (If **with context**) This explanation was written by a respondent who identifies as a **Republican/Democrat**.
- How compelling do you find the reasoning in each of these arguments to be? [Similar response format]
- 4. **Taiwan arguments:** Please read the following arguments about Taiwan carefully, and then answer the questions that follow.
 - Proposition: Send American ships and troops to help defend Taiwan, if China invades Taiwan.
 - **Explanation #1:** \${e://Field/taiwan_arg1}
 - * (If **with context**) This explanation was written by a respondent who identifies as a **Republican/Democrat**.
 - **Explanation #2:** \${e://Field/taiwan_arg2}
 - * (If **with context**) This explanation was written by a respondent who identifies as a **Republican/Democrat**.
 - Having read the explanations above, where would you place yourself on the 10-point scale you saw earlier? Remember, you should place yourself at 0 or 10 only if your feelings about this issue are extremely intense.
 - Sending American ships and troops to help defend Taiwan, if China invaded Taiwan

-
- * Response format is a sliding scale from 0-10, with 0 labeled as “Strongly oppose this policy,” 10 labeled as “Strongly favor this policy,” and 5 labeled as “Neither favor nor oppose this policy.”
 - **New page:** As a reminder, here are the explanations you just read. Please scroll to the bottom of the page to answer another question about them.
 - **Explanation #1:** `#{e://Field/taiwan_arg1}`
 - * (If **with context**) This explanation was written by a respondent who identifies as a **Republican/Democrat**.
 - **Explanation #2:** `#{e://Field/taiwan_arg2}`
 - * (If **with context**) This explanation was written by a respondent who identifies as a **Republican/Democrat**.
 - How compelling do you find the reasoning in each of these arguments to be? [Similar response format]

3 EXAMINING ATYPICAL ARGUMENTS

To better understand how the atypical arguments in our study differ from typical ones, we conducted three exploratory analyses systematically examining the attributes of the Green and Gun issue arguments that were presented to our Receivers. We focus on only these two policies because the remaining two policy areas have weaker partisan divides, meaning atypicality is mostly a Receiver perception, rather than an objective argument property. We examined 1) argument style, using an existing automated approach (Yeomans et al. 2019); 2) argument style, using a hand coding procedure we independently developed an applied; and 3) the substantive considerations each argument raised, also using a self-created procedure. We describe each of these analyses in turn.

3.1 Argument style: automated approach

Politeness is widely recognized as a language attribute that, likely because it signals respect for the receiver, makes messages more likely to be perceived as persuasive and informative (Brown and Levinson 1987; Brooks and Geer 2007). After observing our results, we conjectured that atypical arguments might be more polite than typical ones. As a first test of this conjecture, we invoked the R package *Politeness*, created by Yeomans, Kantor, and Tingley (2019), which was developed to identify and code politeness in natural language. We focus on a model trained to identify “receptiveness to opposing views” which aims to capture a speaker’s willingness to engage with views different from their own. The model relied on several features of politeness to generate a receptiveness score for each argument that could take on a value from -1 (least receptive) to 1 (most receptive). The 17 features that make up receptiveness were: 1) Hedges; 2) Impersonal pronouns; 3) Negation; 4) Informal title; 5) Reasoning; 6) Contrasting conjunction; 7) First person plural; 8) Positive emotion; 9) Negative emotion; 10) Agreement; 11) Disagreement; 12) Acknowledgment; 13) Subjectivity; 14) WH Questions (why/how/etc.); 15) Yes/No questions; 16) Truth intensifier; 17) Adverb limiter.

We regressed these receptiveness scores on atypicality. As Table 4 shows, Atypical arguments register as higher on receptiveness than typical ones.

TABLE 4. Receptiveness and atypicality

	Receptiveness
Intercept	−0.239*** (0.015)
Atypical	0.051* (0.022)
Num.Obs.	224
R2	0.023
R2 Adj.	0.019

Note: * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$., *** $p < 0.001$. Standard errors in parentheses. Receptiveness is scaled -1 to 1.

3.2 Argument style: hand-coding

Although the *Politeness* package provides an objective *a priori* approach for assessing argument style, we were uncertain, having read the arguments that were used in our study, that it would capture the most relevant stylistic elements that might distinguish typical and atypical arguments. For instance, several elements coded by the *Politeness* package seem geared toward interactive in-person conversations (such as a statement using the word “please”). To examine typical and atypical arguments in a different, complementary way, we also developed our own coding scheme focused on “nice” stylistic attributes that, having read the arguments in our study, we thought might distinguish typical and atypical ones. We coded five argument attributes, with each incrementing or decrementing a summary “conciliatoriness” score for each argument, as follows.

1. Orientation toward detractors: critical vs. validating.
 - (a) Critical or derisive toward detractors (-1)
 - (b) Neutral toward detractors (0)
 - (c) Validating of detractors (+1)
2. Nuance. Nuanced arguments make finely-grained distinctions, acknowledge limitations, or offer caveats. Non-nuanced arguments paints in broad strokes and traffics in absolutes.
 - (a) Not very nuanced (0)
 - (b) Nuanced (+1)
3. Ambivalence. Does the argument author express any mixed feelings about their stated position?
 - (a) No ambivalence (0)
 - (b) Ambivalence (+1)
4. Personal narrative. Does the argument invoke personal or biographical information? (See Kubin et al. 2021; Naunov et al. 2025.)
 - (a) No personal narrative (0)
 - (b) Invokes a personal narrative (+1)
5. Humility. Does the argument acknowledge lack of knowledge, understanding, or information?
 - (a) No expression of humility (0)
 - (b) Expresses humility (+1)

TABLE 5. Atypicality and argument conciliatoriness

	GreenCON	GreenLIB	GunCON	GunLIB
Atypical = 1	−0.067 (0.214)	0.133 (0.119)	−0.038 (0.234)	0.200 (0.151)
Intercept	0.667** (0.151)	0.233** (0.084)	0.967** (0.132)	0.300** (0.107)
Num.Obs.	60	60	44	60
R2	0.002	0.021	0.001	0.029
R2 Adj.	−0.016	0.004	−0.023	0.013

* p < .05, ** p < .01., Standard errors in parentheses.

Two coders, blind to whether an argument had been classified as typical or atypical, independently applied this coding scheme to all the arguments displayed in our study. All coding disagreements were resolved by discussion. If the two coders could not agree on how to code a specific argument, a third coder resolved the impasse.

Coded this way, argument conciliatoriness ranged from -1 to 3, with the largest bulk of arguments having scores of either zero (50.5%) or one (39.9%). We regress this outcome on an indicator variable for each argument being atypical (versus typical). Table 5 shows the results. While atypical conservative arguments are not associated with conciliatoriness (columns 1 and 3), there is suggestive evidence that liberal ones are. In column 2, atypical liberal arguments on the Green policy are 0.133 points nicer than typical ones ($p = .27$). In column 4, atypical liberal arguments on the Gun policy are 0.200 points nicer than typical ones ($p = .19$). Pooled, the atypical liberal arguments on these two policies are 0.166 points higher in conciliatoriness than the typical ones ($SE = 0.096$, $p = 0.08$).

3.3 Argument substance

We also wished to examine whether atypical arguments were substantively different than typical ones—whether the two kinds of arguments raise a different range of substantive considerations. To examine whether or not they do, we developed an approach to hand code the considerations raised by each argument. Two researchers reviewed all the arguments of a specific type (e.g. liberal arguments about Green energy policy, whether typical or atypical). Each coder identified the ten most prominent considerations that seemed to arise for each argument type. Then, a third researcher reviewed the two consideration lists and consolidated them by combining topics with high conceptual overlap and eliminating seemingly less important topics, until the total number of topics per argument type was at most eight. Table 6 reports the substantive considerations we identified. Some of these are repeated across both liberal and conservative sides of a specific policy area. Others are specific to a topic side.

Next, arguments were coded in a similar fashion as for the Conciliatoriness coding above—with the difference that the coding scheme was different for each argument type. That is, two coders, blind to argument typicality or atypicality, independently coded the presence or absence of each consideration in each argument. (Considerations were not mutually exclusive: in principle, a single argument could raise all or none of them.) Coding disagreements were resolved by discussion or, if the initial two coders could not agree, by a third coder.

TABLE 6. Considerations coded for each argument type

GreenCON	GreenLIB	GunCON	GunLIB
(1) Planetary effects and global warming	(1) Planetary effects and global warming	(1) Teachers' ability to handle firearms	(1) Teachers' ability to handle firearms
(2) Individual choice and consumer freedom	(2) Individual choice and consumer freedom	(2) Normalization of gun violence	(2) Normalization of gun violence
(3) Economic effects (benefits or consequences)	(3) Economic effects (benefits or consequences)	(3) Inadequacy of other policies	(3) Inadequacy of other policies
(4) Practical concerns about feasibility	(4) Natural resources and renewable energy	(4) Secure storage considerations	(4) Secure storage considerations
(5) Culture or history of gas-powered cars	(5) Public health	(5) Deterrence	(5) Effects on learning
(6) Affordability	(6) Foreign affairs	(6) Speed of shooter response	(6) Complications during active shooter
(7) EV skepticism	(7) Responsibilities or restrictions on government	(7) Real or perceived safety improvements	
(8) Mining practices or battery disposal			

Because we did not approach this analysis with strong prior expectations about how typical versus atypical arguments would differ on any particular consideration, we compare the two argument types holistically, asking whether they differ in the overall profile of considerations they raise. A standard way to do so is to conceptualize the consideration codes for each argument as a vector identifying a location in multidimensional space. We then use multivariate analysis of variance (MANOVA) to estimate the distance between the conditional mean vectors for typical and atypical arguments, with inference based on Pillai’s trace (Rencher and Christensen 2012).¹² This statistic provides an omnibus test of the null hypothesis that the mean vectors are equal across groups. Statistically significant results in these analyses indicate that typical and atypical arguments present readers with meaningfully different bundles of considerations.

TABLE 7. MANOVA omnibus test (Pillai’s trace) by topic

Topic	N (args)	Dims kept	Pillai	F	p
GunLIB	60	6	0.196	2.15	0.062
GunCON	44	6	0.061	0.40	0.873
GreenLIB	60	5	0.192	2.56	0.037
GreenCON	60	8	0.134	0.99	0.457

Table 7 reports Pillai’s trace and associated F-statistics and p-values for each argument type. For liberal arguments about guns in schools, the null hypothesis is rejected at $p < .07$. For liberal arguments about green energy, the null is rejected at $p < .04$. For the remaining two topics, we do not reject the null. These results overlap with those reported in Table 5 in that we observe starker differences between typical and atypical arguments for directionally liberal arguments than for conservative ones. We take these results as evidence that typical and atypical arguments differ in the substantive considerations they raise, though extent of the differences may vary across topics.

In summary, we have found, in three different analyses, some evidence that typical and atypical arguments are distinctive types that might influence readers differently. However, we readily acknowledge that the evidence is suggestive—statistically significant in only one instance of Table 7 and arising more from liberal-leaning than conservative-leaning arguments.

4 ADDITIONAL ANALYSES

4.1 Atypical issue positions in the ANES

To get a sense of the commonality of atypical policy stances within the broader public, we examine the 2024 American National Election Studies Time Series. We examine 17 policy questions with clear liberal/conservative. The policies are listed in Table 8. To avoid classifying mixed or ambivalently-held positions as sincere, we classify respondents as adopting a liberal or conservative position only when they endorse the most extreme version of a policy (e.g. favoring or opposing DEI programs “a great deal”).

¹²Because the Pillai’s trace statistic can be unstable in the face of extremely rare binary features, we exclude argument attributes that occur in less than 5% of arguments. Table 7 reports the number of dimensions retained for each argument type.

TABLE 8. Policies Examined within the 2024 ANES

Policy	Variable	Liberal position	Conservative position	Scale points
DEI on college campuses	V241290x	Favor DEI programs	Oppose DEI programs	7
Abortion	V241302	Always permitted	Never permitted	4
Death penalty	V241308x	Oppose death penalty	Favor death penalty	4
Photo ID to vote	V241319x	Oppose photo ID requirement	Favor photo ID requirement	7
Felon voting	V241322x	Allow felons to vote	Oppose felon voting	7
Climate action	V241366x	Gov. should do much more	Gov. should do less	7
Paid parental leave	V241369x	Favor employer mandate	Oppose employer mandate	7
Transgender bathrooms	V241372x	Favor transgender access	Oppose transgender access	7
Transgender sports ban	V241375x	Oppose ban	Favor ban	7
Gay job discrimination	V241378x	Favor anti-discrimination laws	Oppose anti-discrimination laws	4
Same-sex adoption	V241381x	Allow same-sex adoption	Oppose same-sex adoption	6
Same-sex marriage	V241385x	Favor same-sex marriage	Oppose same-sex marriage	7
Birthright citizenship	V241389x	Oppose ending birthright	Favor ending birthright	7
Childhood arrivals (DACA)	V241392x	Allow to stay	Send back	6
Border wall	V241395x	Oppose border wall	Favor border wall	7
Weapons aid to Ukraine	V241400x	Favor weapons aid	Oppose weapons aid	7
Humanitarian aid to Palestinians	V241406x	Favor humanitarian aid	Oppose humanitarian aid	7

Note: Policy opinions coded in the 2024 ANES Time Series. To avoid misclassifying ambivalent or centrist opinions, respondents are classified as endorsing a liberal/conservative policy position only when they select the most extreme response for a given policy.

TABLE 9. Receivers' Policy Positions

Policy	Republican Receivers			Democratic Receivers		
	Conservative	Liberal	Neutral	Conservative	Liberal	Neutral
Green	51.47	34.56	13.97	15.64	73.01	11.35
Gun	31.11	51.11	17.78	3.64	92.42	3.94
Nuclear	58.09	14.71	27.21	43.17	38.20	18.63
Taiwan	54.48	27.61	17.91	57.36	26.38	16.26

Note. The following policy positions are coded as conservative: opposing ending the sale of new gas-powered cars and trucks by 2035 (Green); allowing teachers and school officials to carry guns in K-12 schools (Gun); favoring building new nuclear power plants to generate power in the United States (Nuclear); opposing sending American ships and troops to help defend Taiwan, if China invaded. The contrary positions are coded as liberal.

TABLE 10. Row-normalized proportions of Atypicality by Congruence (Green Issue)

	typical	atypical
neutral	0.538	0.462
Incongruent	0.515	0.485
Congruent	0.493	0.507

Note:

Chi-squared test: $\chi^2 = 0.95$, $df = 2$, $p = 0.621$

4.2 Senders' Policy Positions

Table 9 is parallel to Table 1 in the main text, but for the Receivers in our study.

4.3 Background on Congruence Control

As we note throughout the main text, the possibility that atypicality effects would be different for in-party versus out-party arguments occurred to us after we filed our preregistration. Accounting for this conditionality necessitates two departures from our pre-registered model. Most obviously, we introduce an *Atypical* $\times$ *OutParty* interaction term, as discussed under “Estimation approach and deviations” in the main text. More subtly, introducing this interaction term also requires us to add a control variable to account for the obvious confounding effect of argument congruence. This section elaborates on why adding the *Atypical* $\times$ *OutParty* interaction term to our model necessitates the additional control variable.

First, consider that argument congruence—whether the argument reinforces or challenges a respondent’s existing attitudes—is an obvious antecedent for how the argument will be received (e.g. Taber & Lodge 2006).

For this reason, we sought a design that would make argument congruence orthogonal to argument typicality. Indeed, in our full sample, it is. Consider, for instance, the joint distribution of typicality and congruence for the Green policy arguments that were displayed to our respondents (other policies are similar). This joint distribution is displayed in Table 10.

The independence is an implication of the sampling process described under “Vetting and selecting arguments”: among the arguments taking any particular stance (e.g. the liberal stance on Green energy),

TABLE 11. Row-normalized proportions of Atypicality by Congruence (Green Issue—Inparty arguments)

	typical	atypical
neutral	0.500	0.500
Incongruent	0.236	0.764
Congruent	0.759	0.241
<i>Note:</i>		
Chi-squared test: $\chi^2 = 107.15$, $df = 2$, $p < 0.001$		

TABLE 12. Row-normalized proportions of Atypicality by Congruence (Green Issue—Outparty arguments)

	typical	atypical
neutral	0.556	0.444
Congruent	0.780	0.220
Incongruent	0.210	0.790
<i>Note:</i>		
Chi-squared test: $\chi^2 = 128.71$, $df = 2$, $p < 0.001$		

half come from Democrats and half come from Republicans. Similarly, half the arguments arguing for a conservative stance on Green energy come from Democrats and half come from Republicans. Which policy side counts as congruent is determined by a Receiver's own policy stances—but the orthogonality holds in either case.

A difficulty arises, however, when we condition the analysis on Receiver in-party. Tables 11 and 12 present identical joint distributions segmented by in-party and out-party. They reveal clear dependence between typicality and congruence.

The reason for the conditional dependence is readily understandable. Imagine a Receiver who herself is typical, in that she holds the party-typical policy stance (she's a Democrat with a liberal policy position) and has typical typicality perceptions (she believed Democrats typically hold liberal policy positions). For this Receiver, arguments from typical Democratic Senders will be reinforcing, just as arguments from atypical Democratic Senders will be challenging (the pattern in Table 11). By the same token, arguments from typical Republican Senders will be challenging and from atypical Republicans will be reinforcing (the pattern in Table 12). This is a clear example of potential collider bias (Pearl 2009, ch. 3).

Including a control for congruence is a solution to this issue. Doing so removes the shared variance between atypicality and congruence, blocking the path for potential confounding.

4.4 Persuasion Outcome

Table 13 shows outcomes for a persuasion variable.

4.5 Regression Models Underlying Figure 2

The regression models underlying Figure 2 in the main text are presented in Table 14.

TABLE 13. Atypicality effects on persuasion.

	All	With Author Info	No Author Info
Prior opinion	0.735** (0.014)	0.757** (0.019)	0.714** (0.020)
Atypical = 1	0.002 (0.008)	0.011 (0.010)	−0.007 (0.011)
Gun policy = 1	−0.011 (0.010)	0.010 (0.014)	−0.033* (0.015)
Nuclear policy = 1	0.010 (0.010)	0.008 (0.014)	0.011 (0.015)
Taiwan policy = 1	−0.009 (0.010)	−0.002 (0.014)	−0.017 (0.015)
Intercept	0.186** (0.011)	0.160** (0.016)	0.213** (0.017)
$\sigma_{Receivers}$	0.056	0.045	0.065
$\sigma_{Arg. Sets}$	0.030	0.040	0.027
$\sigma_{Residual}$	0.153	0.146	0.157
Num.Obs.	1870	945	925
R2 Marg.	0.592	0.617	0.570
R2 Cond.	0.651	0.673	0.641

Note: * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$., Standard errors in parentheses. The outcome—persuasion—is scaled from zero to one.

4.6 Anchored Atypicality

Table 15 shows estimates for atypicality effects, where atypicality has a stable meaning (determined by the researcher) for each issue—rather than being defined according to Receiver perceptions of what policy stances are typical versus not. Here, we stipulate typical issue stances to be Democrats favoring a shift away from gas-powered cars; Democrats opposing teachers carrying guns in schools; Democrats opposing expansion of nuclear energy; and Democrats opposing intervention in Taiwan. We readily acknowledge that the latter two definitions are judgment calls—a necessary byproduct of our desire to examine two issues less strongly grounded in partisan divisions.

4.7 Issue-by-issue analysis

Figure 4 reports atypicality effects (perception-coded) broken out for each issue in our study (divided by columns), as well as depending on whether Sender partisan information is present (top row) or hidden (bottom row). Figure 5 reports the same analysis for the anchored version of our atypicality variable.

4.8 Analysis of Pure Independents

Pure independent respondents cannot be included in the analysis in Figure 2 (and similar), since the Out-party variable is not defined for them. Here, we analyze them separately. To do so, we estimate models similar to Equation (1)—but omitting the Out-party variable. Figure 6 shows the results.

Among independents, the marginal effect of atypical arguments when Sender partisan information

TABLE 14. Atypicality effects on argument compellingness.

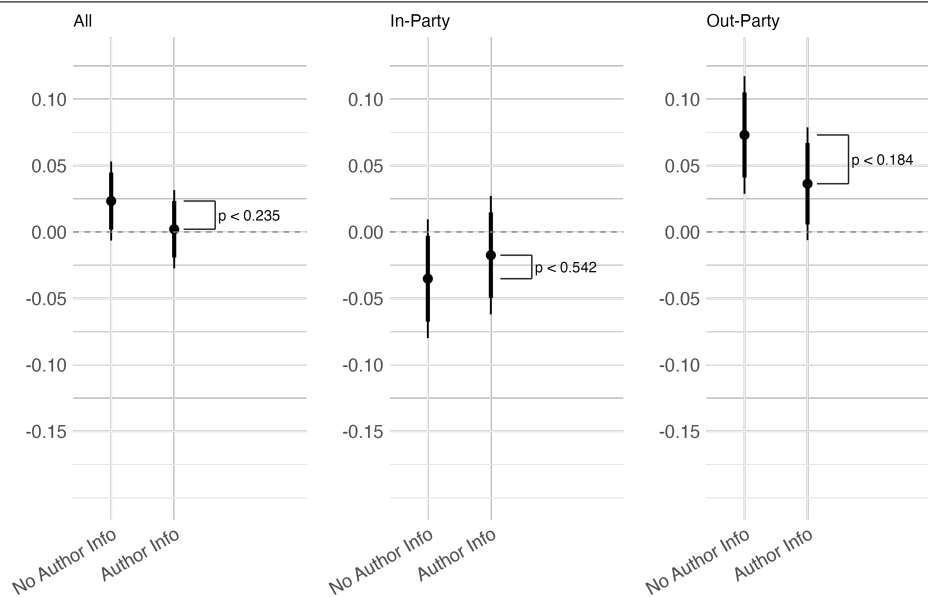
	All	With Author Info	No Author Info
Atypical = 1	–0.050** (0.016)	–0.001 (0.021)	–0.105** (0.023)
Out-party Sender = 1	–0.067** (0.015)	–0.018 (0.019)	–0.121** (0.022)
Atypical × Out-party	0.086** (0.021)	0.012 (0.028)	0.174** (0.032)
Congruent = 1	0.080** (0.016)	0.092** (0.022)	0.067** (0.023)
Incongruent = 1	–0.073** (0.016)	–0.092** (0.023)	–0.059* (0.024)
Gun policy = 1	–0.036* (0.017)	–0.035 (0.020)	–0.034 (0.021)
Nuclear policy = 1	–0.021 (0.017)	–0.053** (0.020)	0.005 (0.021)
Taiwan policy = 1	–0.065** (0.017)	–0.078** (0.020)	–0.050* (0.021)
Intercept	0.597** (0.021)	0.577** (0.029)	0.622** (0.029)
$\sigma_{Receivers}$	0.164	0.176	0.149
$\sigma_{Arguments}$	0.081	0.080	0.079
$\sigma_{Residual}$	0.245	0.234	0.256
Num.Obs.	3408	1727	1681
R2 Marg.	0.073	0.082	0.081
R2 Cond.	0.404	0.456	0.361

Note: * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$., Standard errors in parentheses. The outcome—argument compellingness—is scaled from zero to one. Atypicality is coded according to Receiver perceptions.

TABLE 15. Atypicality effects (anchored) on argument compellingness.

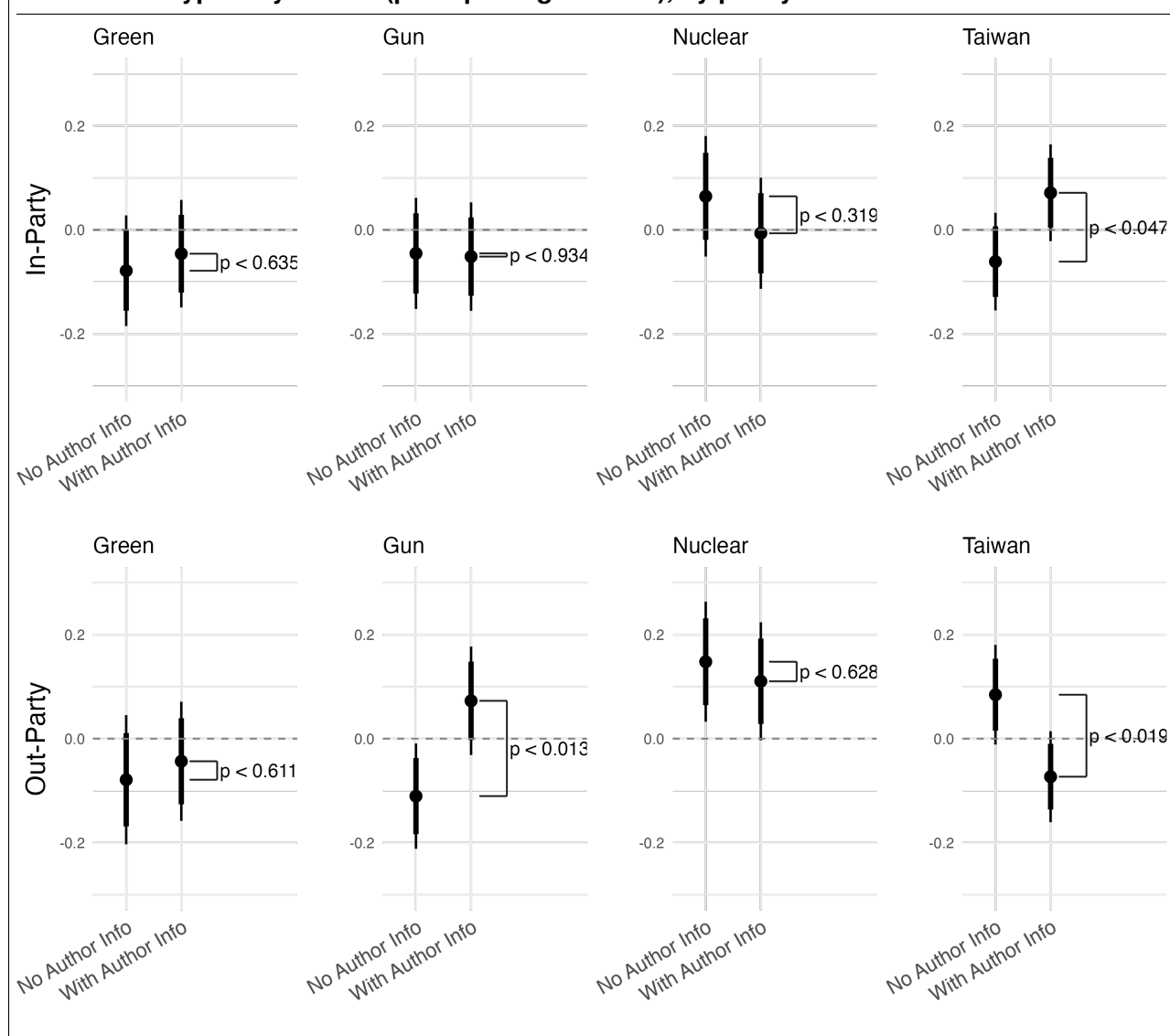
	All	With Author Info	No Author Info
Atypical (anchored) = 1	−0.029 (0.016)	−0.021 (0.021)	−0.044* (0.022)
Out-party Sender = 1	−0.069** (0.014)	−0.048** (0.019)	−0.100** (0.021)
Atypical × Out-party	0.083** (0.020)	0.054* (0.027)	0.128** (0.030)
Congruent = 1	0.082** (0.015)	0.089** (0.021)	0.074** (0.022)
Incongruent = 1	−0.075** (0.016)	−0.089** (0.022)	−0.066** (0.023)
Gun policy = 1	−0.035* (0.017)	−0.035 (0.020)	−0.034 (0.020)
Nuclear policy = 1	−0.018 (0.016)	−0.043* (0.020)	0.006 (0.020)
Taiwan policy = 1	−0.061** (0.016)	−0.076** (0.020)	−0.038 (0.020)
Intercept	0.587** (0.021)	0.589** (0.029)	0.592** (0.028)
$\sigma_{Receivers}$	0.164	0.173	0.153
$\sigma_{Arguments}$	0.082	0.083	0.075
$\sigma_{Residual}$	0.244	0.234	0.255
Num.Obs.	3644	1833	1811
R2 Marg.	0.072	0.082	0.072
R2 Cond.	0.407	0.452	0.360

Note: * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$., Standard errors in parentheses. This Table is identical to Table 14 in the main text, except it uses the anchored, rather than perceptual-based version of the atypicality variable. The outcome—perceived argument compellingness—is scaled from zero to one.

FIGURE 3. Marginal effect of atypicality (anchored) on argument compellingness

Note: This figure is identical to Figure 2 in the main text, except it uses the anchored, rather than perceptual-based version of the atypicality variable. Point estimates are estimated marginal effects of atypicality on perceived argument compellingness. Within each panel, there are separate estimates for arguments originating from in-party and out-party senders. Thick bars are 84% confidence intervals. Thin bars are 95% confidence intervals. The dependent variable is scaled 0–1.

FIGURE 4. Atypicality effects (perception-grounded), by policy.



is hidden is negative and not significant ($ME = -0.024$, $SE = 0.043$, $p = .57$). When Sender partisan information is visible, the same effect is positive and significant ($ME = 0.093$, $SE = 0.045$, $p < .05$). For the interaction term testing equivalence of these estimates, $\beta = 0.116$, $SE = 0.062$, $p = .07$.

4.9 Pre-registered regression model

We report our pre-registered models in Table 16.

REFERENCES FOR SUPPORTING INFORMATION

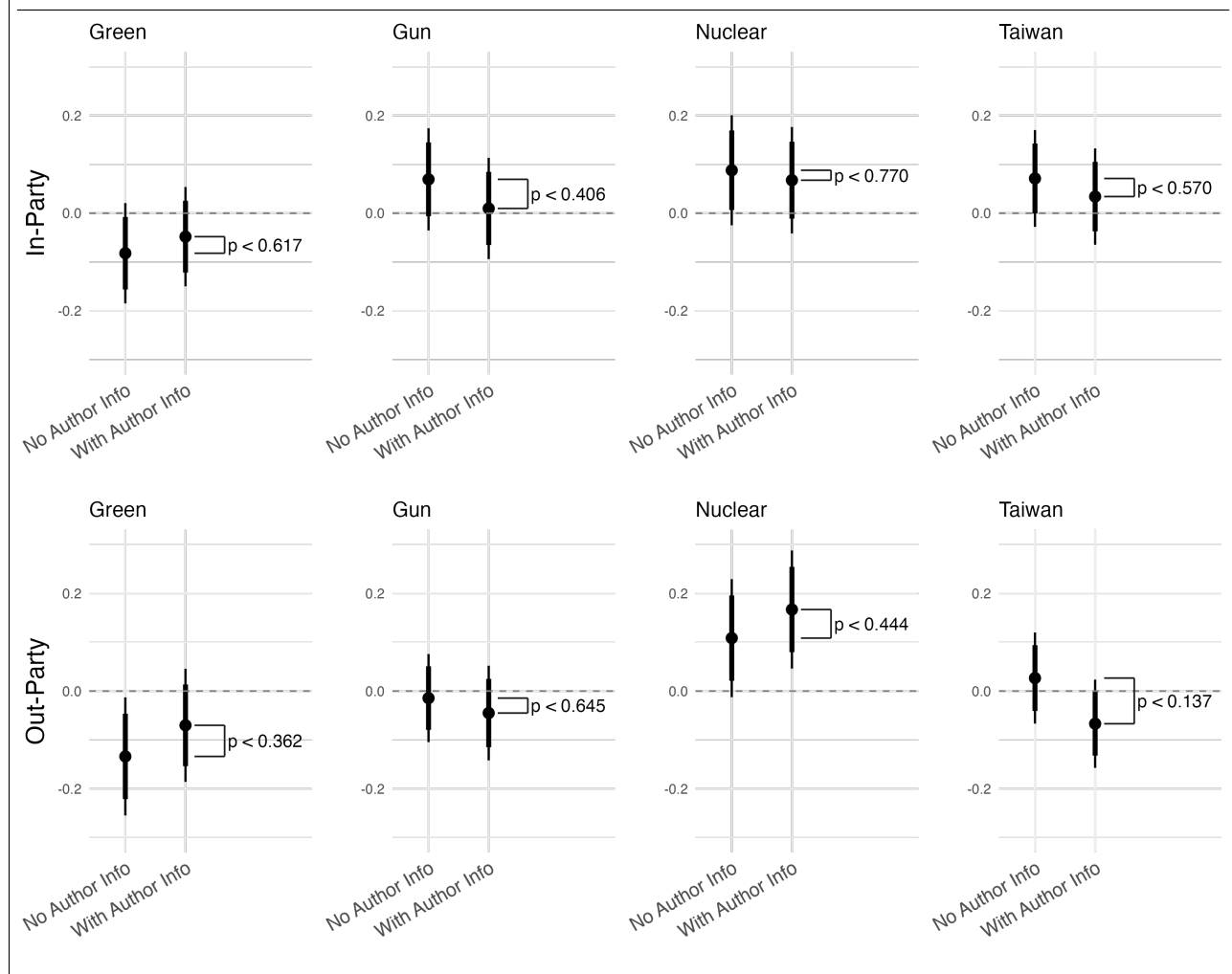
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TABLE 16. Pre-registered models

	Persuasion	Persuasion	Compellingness	Compellingness
Prior opinion	0.735** (0.014)	0.736** (0.014)		
Atypical = 1	0.002 (0.008)	−0.006 (0.011)	−0.008 (0.011)	−0.017 (0.014)
With author info = 1		−0.015 (0.012)		−0.016 (0.020)
Atypical × AuthorInfo		0.015 (0.015)		0.018 (0.019)
Gun policy = 1	−0.011 (0.010)	−0.012 (0.010)	−0.020 (0.018)	−0.020 (0.018)
Nuclear policy = 1	0.010 (0.010)	0.009 (0.010)	−0.020 (0.018)	−0.020 (0.018)
Taiwan policy = 1	−0.009 (0.010)	−0.010 (0.011)	−0.057** (0.018)	−0.057** (0.018)
Intercept	0.186** (0.011)	0.194** (0.013)	0.567** (0.016)	0.575** (0.018)
$\sigma_{Receivers}$	0.056	0.056	0.168	0.168
$\sigma_{Residual}$	0.153	0.153	0.250	0.250
$\sigma_{Arguments}$			0.099	0.098
$\sigma_{Arg. Sets}$	0.030	0.030		
Num.Obs.	1870	1870	3790	3790
R2 Marg.	0.592	0.592	0.004	0.005
R2 Cond.	0.651	0.651	0.381	0.381

Note: * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$., Standard errors in parentheses. Both outcomes are scaled 0–1.

FIGURE 5. Atypicality effects (anchored), by policy.



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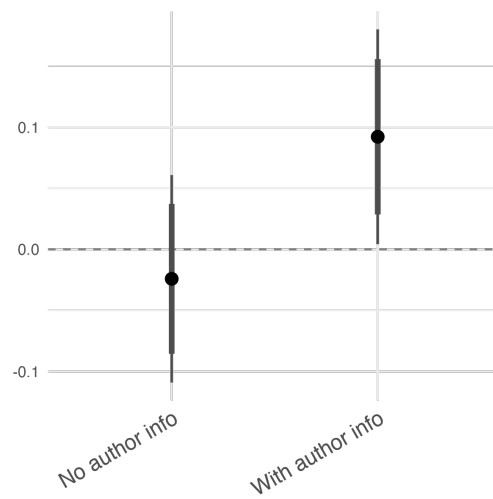
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FIGURE 6. Atypicality effects, Pure Independents.

Note: Point estimates are estimated marginal effects of atypicality (perception-grounded) on perceived argument compellingness. Thick bars are 84% confidence intervals. Thin bars are 95% confidence intervals. The dependent variable is scaled 0–1.